

The paradox of AI accelerationism and the promise of public interest AI

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SCIENCE • 2 Oct 2025 • Vol 390, Issue 6768 • DOI: 10.1126/science.aeb5789

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Over the past 3 years, the idea that artificial intelligence (AI) development should be accelerated without restraint to drive radical societal change—a phenomenon known as AI accelerationism—has gained traction in Silicon Valley. The most prominent form of this belief is known as “[effective accelerationism](#),” and adherents view unrestricted progress in AI as a solution to humanity’s problems. Rooted in the broader political ideology of accelerationism, this movement positions itself directly in opposition to “AI doomers” or “decelerationists,” who advocate for AI safety and slow, cautious development. Effective accelerationists often dismiss concerns about existential risk, arguing that technological stagnation is a greater danger than uncontrolled advancement. [Public interest AI](#) inverts AI accelerationism, promoting more equitable, sustainable, and democratically accountable technological progress. This approach directly addresses the risks and potential harms of unregulated acceleration by aligning AI with public values rather than solely with private interests.

The ideologies underlying AI accelerationism fall into what is widely known as “[TESCREAL](#),” an acronym for Transhumanism, Extropianism, Singularitarianism, Cosmism, Rationalist ideology, Effective Altruism, and Longtermism. TESCREAL’s constellation of worldviews promotes technological salvation while neglecting present-day social inequalities, justifying extreme wealth accumulation and the concentration of power among tech elites. By focusing on abstract, far-future scenarios, the philosophy’s proponents ignore tangible harms caused by technology in the present, including algorithmic bias, worker exploitation, and systemic discrimination. This focus on rapid and unregulated AI advancement threatens to replicate, deepen, and even automate existing societal inequalities, with many impacts already [visible](#).

Many effective accelerationists believe that powerful, unrestricted AI can solve fundamental human development challenges such as poverty, war, and climate change. However, these viewpoints are driving policies that directly contradict community needs. Although policy-makers create legal provisions to increase chip production, expand data center development, and promote AI adoption, for example, they often systematically ignore the social foundations that support human flourishing, such as robust health care systems, accessible housing, reliable infrastructure, and quality education. A recent policy roadmap drafted by the Trump administration to “[achieve and maintain unquestioned and unchallenged global technological dominance](#)”—alongside plans to cut [housing assistance](#), reduce [health care spending](#), and suspend [foreign aid funding](#)—exemplifies the prioritization of geopolitical interests over social welfare. Accelerating AI without sufficient safeguards will likely continue exacerbating negative social impacts and has already resulted in measurable [environmental consequences](#) that have harmed marginalized communities, consumed precious water resources, and increased air pollution.

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Given the United States’ outsized influence on AI development, the country’s priorities for and governance decisions about AI acceleration considerably impact the global AI ecosystem. Silicon Valley’s race to accelerate AI development while overlooking systemic social failures risks entrenching socioeconomic inequality even further, endangering millions of Americans and hundreds of millions globally, given that mainstream AI technologies still exhibit major [cultural](#) and [linguistic](#) shortcomings. The purported benefits of AI accelerationism are also least likely to reach communities in the world’s poorest countries, regions that primarily constitute the Global Majority, where tech companies exploit nations through [digital labor](#), [mineral extraction](#), and sales of AI-powered [surveillance](#) technologies. As these countries struggle to compete with current AI powers, they risk relegation to the lower rungs of the AI hierarchy, where limited economic benefits and decreased digital sovereignty reduce their ability to steer their technological futures.

Overall, these problems raise numerous questions. Who benefits when a country aims to be a world leader in AI without addressing basic social problems? What value exists in developing the most powerful AI models when such innovations further exacerbate existing social ills? How can we reimagine AI development and accelerationism in a way that promotes advancement across all domains of human life?

Public interest AI centers intentional, values-aligned progress for social good rather than promoting unrestricted technological advancement for its own sake. Embracing public oversight and regulation—a key tenet of public interest AI—prevents harm and ensures equitable outcomes, rejecting the false premise that guardrails and regulations necessarily impede AI progress. Public interest AI also distributes technological control among diverse stakeholders, including governments, civil society, academia, and the public rather than concentrating power among a few private firms driven by profit incentives. It fundamentally shifts how success is measured in AI systems, benchmarking progress based on public benefit, accountability, and the advancement of human and planetary well-being rather than standard metrics such as speed, scale, and profitability. Although AI neither is, nor will ever be, a panacea for socioeconomic development challenges, prioritizing societal benefits over short-term commercial gains can position AI development as a crucial enabler of progress. Instead of “moving fast and breaking things”—a guiding principle of Facebook’s company culture coined by founder Mark Zuckerberg—it is possible that the accelerating capabilities of AI can be harnessed for specific, tangible, and democratically guided public benefits.

We can continue accelerating toward an AI-powered future that amplifies existing inequities, or we can deliberately steer toward one that increases prospects for shared global prosperity. The question isn’t whether we can afford to slow down, but whether we can afford not to change direction.

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